Embedded System Design and Modeling

IX. Scheduling basics

Scheduling

- Scheduling = the process of arranging the execution of a set of **tasks** (runnables, threads, processes) which need to be run on the same processing device
  - i.e. decide which task is run when, for how long, etc.
- Encountered in multi-tasking systems
- Problems:
  - How to decide which task to run when?
  - Tasks can become deadlocked
- *Note*: Slides are heavily based on Prabal Dutta & Edward A. Lee, Berkeley 2017

Task

- A **task** is a set of operations which have:
  - release (arrival) time: earliest time when it can be run
  - **start time**: actual starting time
  - **finish time**: actual ending time
  - execution time: actual running time, excluding any interruptions
  - **deadline**: latest time by which a task must be completed
- Tasks may be interrupted (preempted) by higher priority tasks, when priorities are defined
- Tasks may be periodic (e.g. run every 10 ms) or aperiodic

Task

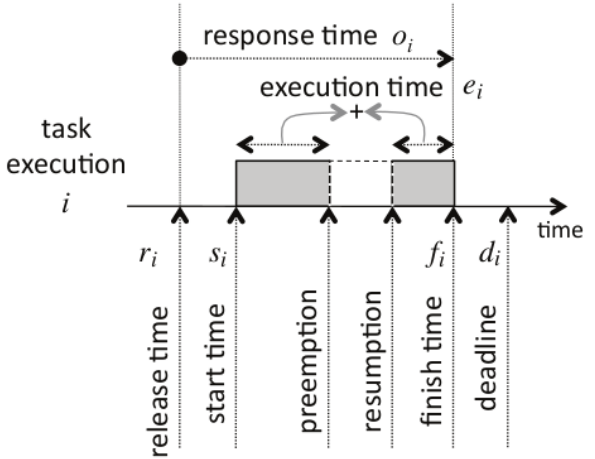


Figure 12.1: Summary of times associated with a task execution.

Figure 1: Task attributes

Scheduling

- The scheduling problem: Given a set of tasks with their own times, which all need to run on the same processor, how to decide which task to run when?
- Typically a job for the operating system (kernel)

Considerations:

- Preemptive vs. non-preemptive scheduling
- Periodic vs. aperiodic tasks
- Fixed priority vs. dynamic priority
- Priority inversion anomalies
- Other scheduling anomalies

Preemptive vs. non-preemptive

- Non-preemptive: once started, no task can be interrupted until it finishes
- Preemptive: a task can be interrupted (the OS decides exactly when)
- Scheduling for preemptive systems is more complex:
  - Every task has a **priority**
  - At any instant, the task with the **highest priority** must be executed
  - Any high priority task must take precedence over a lower priority task

Rate Monotonic Scheduling (RMS)

- Algorithm for scheduling periodic tasks
- Given N **periodic** tasks, how to assign priorities to them?
- **Rate Monotonic Scheduling (RMS)**: assign task priority by period: task with smaller period has higher priority

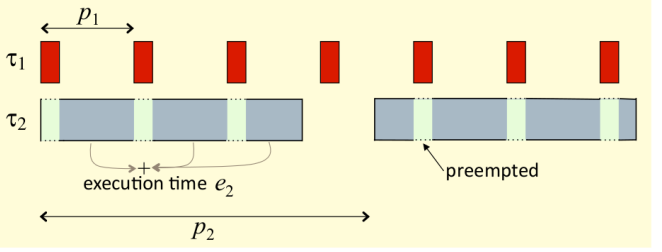


Figure 12.3: Two periodic tasks $T = \{\tau_1, \tau_2\}$ with a preemptive schedule that gives higher priority to τ_1.

[1] image from Lee&Sheshia book

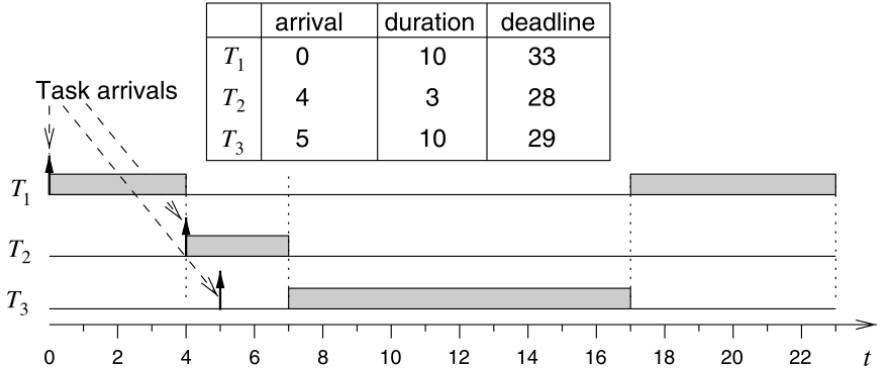
Optimality of RMS

- A **feasible schedule** = all task finish times are at or before their deadlines
  - no deadline is exceeded
- **Theorem**: If the set of N tasks can be arranged to form a feasible schedule, then the RMS scheduling is feasible.

Earliest Deadline First (EDF)

- Algorithm for scheduling non-periodic tasks
- Given N non-periodic independent tasks with arbitrary arrival times and deadlines
- **Earliest Deadline First** (EDF) scheduling: execute the task with the earliest deadline among all available tasks
- Note: If a new task that just arrived can interrupt the current task, in case it has an earlier deadline

Earliest Deadline First (EDF)



	arrival	duration	deadline
T_1	0	10	33
T_2	4	3	28
T_3	5	10	29

Figure 6.6. EDF schedule

[2]

[2] image from "Embedded System Design" 2nd edition, Peter Marwedel, Springer 2011

Earliest Deadline First (EDF)

Explanations for EDF example:

- At time 0 we have only task T1, start executing it
- At time 4 task T2 arrives, with deadline 28 which is smaller than T1's deadline 33. Interrupt T1 and start executing T2
- At time 5 task T3 arrives, with deadline 29 which is later than T2's deadline. Keep executing T2
- At time 7 task T2 finishes. Out of T1 and T3, T3 has the earliest deadline, so start executing T3
- At time 17 task T3 finishes. Only T1 is left, so resume executing T1 until it finishes

Optimality of EDF

- **Theorem**: EDF scheduling minimizes the maximum lateness of the tasks
- The **maximum lateness** of a set of N tasks is:

$$L_{max} = \max(f_i - d_i)$$

  i.e. the maximum difference between completion time and deadline.

  - f_i is the actual finish time of the task
  - d_i is the deadline of the task, i.e. when it was supposed to be finished
  - lateness of a task is $L = f_i - d_i$
  - if $L > 0$, the task is late, i.e. its deadline was exceeded
  - if $L < 0$, the task is early, i.e. it finished ahead of its deadline
- EDF minimizes the maximum lateness among all tasks. If no deadline is exceeded, $L_{max} \leq 0$ and EDF maximizes the safety margin between the finish time and the deadline

Priority Inversion

- Although scheduling looks simple, some complicated and undesired effects might happen (scheduling anomalies) especially when tasks share resources and use critical sections
- **Priority Inversion**: scheduling anomaly where high-priority task is blocked while unrelated lower-priority tasks execute
- Can cause serious problems, such as system resets and data loss
  - Example: Mars Pathfinder mission in 1997.

Priority Inversion

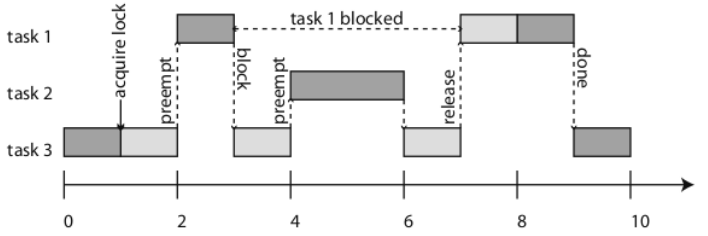


Figure 12.9: Illustration of priority inversion. Task 1 has highest priority, task 3 lowest. Task 3 acquires a lock on a shared object, entering a critical section. It gets preempted by task 1, which then tries to acquire the lock and blocks. Task 2 preempts task 3 at time 4, keeping the higher priority task 1 blocked for an unbounded amount of time. In effect, the priorities of tasks 1 and 2 get inverted, since task 2 can keep task 1 waiting arbitrarily long.

[3] image from Lee&Sheshia book

Avoiding Priority Inversion

- Options for avoiding priority inversion:
  - Priority inheritance
  - Priority ceiling
  - Priority boosting

Priority inheritance protocol:

- When a task blocks while trying to acquire a lock, the task holding the lock **inherits** the priority of the blocked task, if it is higher than its own priority.
- This ensures that the task holding the lock cannot be preempted by a task with lower priority than the blocked task.

Priority inheritance

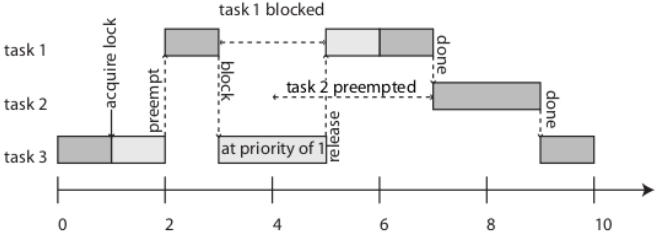


Figure 12.10: Illustration of the priority inheritance protocol. Task 1 has highest priority, task 3 lowest. Task 3 acquires a lock on a shared object, entering a critical section. It gets preempted by task 1, which then tries to acquire the lock and blocks. Task 3 inherits the priority of task 1, preventing preemption by task 2.

[4] image from Lee&Sheshia book

Deadlock

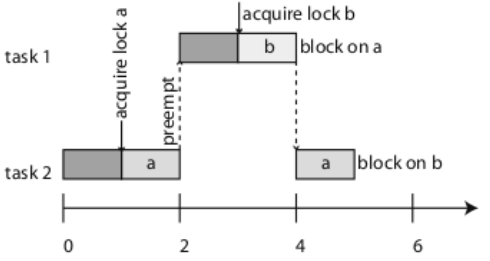


Figure 12.11: Illustration of deadlock. The lower priority task starts first and acquires lock a, then gets preempted by the higher priority task, which acquires lock b and then blocks trying to acquire lock a. The lower priority task then blocks trying to acquire lock b, and no further progress is possible.

[5] image from Lee&Sheshia book

Deadlock

- A task holds a lock A and blocks waiting for a lock B
- Another task holds the lock B and blocks waiting for a lock A
- Result: both tasks are blocked forever

Possible solutions:

- Priority ceiling
- Lock ordering

Priority Ceiling Protocol

- Priorities can be used to prevent certain types of deadlocks
- **Priority ceiling protocol**:
  - Every lock is assigned a priority ceiling, equal to the priority of the highest-priority task that can lock it.
  - A task can acquire a lock only if its priority is **strictly higher** than the priority ceilings of all locks **currently held** by other tasks
- What happens:
  - Suppose all locks can be acquired by any task, so priority ceiling of all locks is equal to P_{max} = maximum priority among all tasks
  - Suppose one task holds a lock A, so priority ceiling of all locks **currently held** is P_{max}
  - Another task cannot hold another lock B unless its priority is **strictly higher** than P_{max} => impossible => can't lock B => no deadlock

Priority Ceiling Protocol

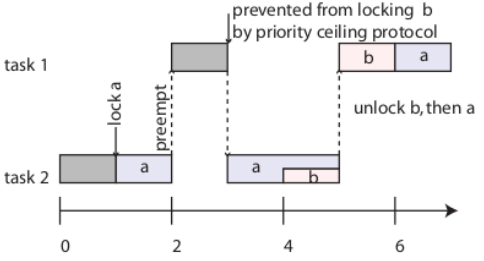


Figure 12.12: Illustration of the priority ceiling protocol. In this version, locks a and b have priority ceilings equal to the priority of task 1. At time 3, task 1 attempts to lock b, but it cannot because task 2 currently holds lock a, which has priority ceiling equal to the priority of task 1.

[6] image from Lee&Sheshia book

Priority Ceiling Protocol

Drawbacks:

- Implementing the priority ceiling protocol requires being able to determine in advance which tasks acquire which locks

Lock ordering

Assign each lock a unique numerical value, and require that locks be acquired in increasing order

Example:

- A system with three locks, A, B, and C, and two threads, T1 and T2.
- We have deadlock if T1 holds A and needs B, and T2 holds B and needs A

Solution with lock ordering:

- Assign each lock a unique numerical value: A=1, B=2, and C=3, and require that locks be acquired in increasing order
- T2 is not allowed to acquire B before A, so "*and T2 holds B and needs A*" is impossible
- T2 must first acquire A before it can get B, so it waits for T1 to release A
- Deadlock is avoided